

In March 1970, while Sihanouk was absent in Europe supposedly for medical care, a parliamentary vote of no confidence removed him as head of state. The war had caused the urban middle class and many in the military to lose faith in Sihanouk's ability to defend the country. Cheng Heng, Chairman of the National Assembly, was appointed interim head of state.



Ready to fire

Troops of the Cambodian army take up firing positions behind a bank near Kampong Cham in the Mekong Delta region in May 1970. Cambodian forces were fighting in operations linked to the US and South Vietnamese incursions that followed the fall of Sihanouk.

New blood

General Lon Nol had not plotted the coup, but in the preceding weeks he had been urging Sihanouk to be tougher with North Vietnam. Public demonstrations in Phnom Penh after the overthrow of Sihanouk provided the pressure for parliamentary leaders to invite Lon Nol to take charge.